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REVIEW ESSAY

East German History and the Crisis of Liberal Democracy

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On September 25, 2017, Germany awoke to the horrifying reality that the Alternative for Germany (AfD), a far-right party founded in 2013, had romped to third place in the previous day's federal election. With 12.6% of the vote, the party became not only the official face of the opposition to Angela Merkel's not-so-grand coalition with the Social Democratic Party (SPD), but also the first far-right party to enter the *Bundestag* since the 1950s. Election watchers soon noticed that the AfD had racked up stunning margins in the states that once made up the German Democratic Republic (GDR), coming in first on the second ballot (*Zweitstimme*) in Saxony and second in Brandenburg, Mecklenburg-Vorpommern, Saxony-Anhalt, and Thuringia.¹ That the AfD, a racist and xenophobic party that campaigns against European integration and immigration, should do so well in once-socialist states bespoke East Germany's strange resonances in German culture and memory nearly thirty years after its dissolution.²

Moreover, it serves as a stark rebuttal to Stefan Heym, who in 1990 bemoaned that the country would become "nothing more than a footnote in world history."³ Though the assertion seems particularly misguided when one considers that interest in the socialist state has only waxed since East German citizens breached the Berlin Wall on the night of November 9, 1989, it does capture a certain deep-seated insecurity at the heart of the historiography on East Germany. Catherine Epstein, for instance, wrote in 2003 that most GDR history had a "dense character" and "may soon vanish without a trace save for dusty library shelves." Ten years later, Andrew Port wrote of the "banalities of East German historiography."⁴ Yet the last two decades have seen an outpouring of interesting, widely-cited scholarship on East Germany. As the works under consideration in this essay attest, that trend has continued in recent years, in part because East German historians have largely left the fraught question of totalitarianism behind, in search of greener pastures.

¹ Jennifer A. Yoder, "Revenge of the East?: The AfD's Appeal in Eastern Germany and Mainstream Parties' Responses," *German Politics and Society* 38, no. 2 (June 2020): 36–37; L. Constantin Wurthmann et al., "Many Losers – One Winner? An Examination of Vote Switching to the AfD in the 2017 German Federal Election Using VAA Data," *Party Politics*, April 16, 2020, 3.

² In the 2021 federal elections, the AfD lost about two percent in the national vote (from 12.6% to 10.3%), making it only the fifth-strongest party in parliament and no longer the official face of the opposition. Nonetheless, the party placed first in the eastern states of Saxony and Thuringia and came in second in two other former East German states. Thus, although the AfD does not appear poised for rapid growth, it remains a threat from the far right and has continued to enjoy outsized success in what used to be East Germany. "Der Bundeswahlleiter," accessed November 19, 2021, <https://www.bundeswahlleiter.de>.

³ Ilko-Sascha Kowalczyk, *Endspiel. Die Revolution von 1989 in der DDR* (Munich: C. H. Beck, 2015), 536.

⁴ Catherine Epstein, "East Germany and Its History since 1989," *The Journal of Modern History* 75, no. 3 (2003): 660; Andrew I. Port, "Introduction: The Banalities of East German Historiography," in *Becoming East German*, ed. Andrew I. Port and Mary Fullbrook (New York: Berghahn Books, 2013), 1.

The original watershed in the historiography on East Germany was, of course, 1989. Soon after the border opened and the Socialist Unity Party (SED) agreed to hold free elections, citizens stormed the headquarters of the Ministry for State Security (MfS, Stasi) in Berlin. They demanded that its files be preserved and made available to the victims of the secret police. The new federal government eventually agreed, and the Stasi Records agency came into being. Starting in 1990, scholars and citizens alike could access records of the secret police, a massive boon for historians of the GDR.⁵ These sources opened up new worlds—no other secret police archive has ever been so accessible to historians. Uncounted articles, dissertations, and monographs sprang from the abundance of the archive, which houses 111 kilometers of files.

Nonetheless, the field was still riven by a central question: just what kind of state had East Germany been? There were those, often with sympathies on the right, who resuscitated the totalitarianism hypothesis, arguing that East Germany was a particularly bad kind of dictatorship, totalitarian in ambition at the very least. These historians emphasized the invasiveness of Stasi intelligence gathering (it was the largest secret police force per capita in world history, retaining some 91,000 employees and 173,000 informants at its apogee⁶), the violence of the Soviet occupation, and the barbarity of the GDR's closed border.⁷ This argument has taken various guises over the years, from Hans-Ulrich Wehler's dismissal of the country as nothing more than a "Russian satrapy," to Alf Lüdtke's concept of a "thoroughly dominated society" (*durchherrschte Gesellschaft*). Such arguments were relics of the Cold War, evidence of a particular mindset bent on making out only the worst of state socialism and only the best of liberal democracy.⁸ Because its function was always ideological, the totalitarianism hypothesis enjoyed its greatest constituency outside the academy, where sensationalized works such as Anna Funder's book *Stasiland* and Florian Henckel von Donnersmarck's film *The Lives of Others* have enjoyed tremendous commercial success.⁹

In opposition to the totalitarianism hypothesis, a growing number of scholars, many writing in English, turned to the history of everyday life in search of evidence that East Germans had enjoyed a degree of personal agency and that the country was not "thoroughly dominated." Taking up Alf Lüdtke's idea of *Eigensinn*—a slippery term that Andrew Demshuk, for instance, defines as "self-conscious selective appropriation and maneuverability in a system of authoritarian top-down strictures and slogans"¹⁰—a new generation of historians revealed just how much autonomy and even political agency ordinary East Germans enjoyed under socialist rule. Pointing to the millions of petitions East Germans submitted to their leaders—what Andrew Port labelled the country's "grumble *Gesellschaft*"—or to the revolutions in sexual mores identified by Josie McLellan, to name two examples, these historians contended that the totalitarian hypothesis was woefully inadequate to the task of explaining

⁵ Barbara Miller, *The Stasi Files Unveiled: Guilt and Compliance in a Unified Germany* (London: Routledge, 2004), 6–7.

⁶ Gary Bruce, *The Firm: The Inside Story of the Stasi* (New York: Oxford University Press, 2010), 10.

⁷ Klaus Schroeder has been a particularly vociferous advocate of the totalitarianism hypothesis. Klaus Schroeder, *Der SED-Staat. Partei, Staat und Gesellschaft* (Munich: Hanser, 1998), 621–48; Klaus Schroeder and Jochen Staadt, "Der diskrete Charme des Status Quo. DDR-Forschung in der Ära der Entspannungspolitik," *Leviathan* 21, no. 1 (1993): 24–63. This language also shows up widely in the Anglophone literature, including Norman M. Naimark, *The Russians in Germany: A History of the Soviet Zone of Occupation, 1945–1949* (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 1995), 397; Charles S. Maier, *Dissolution: The Crisis of Communism and the End of East Germany* (Princeton: Princeton University Press, 1999), 35. See too Corey Ross's excursions on theoretical approaches to the East German state: Corey Ross, *The East German Dictatorship: Problems and Perspectives in the Interpretation of the GDR* (New York: Bloomsbury, 2002), 19–43.

⁸ Hans-Ulrich Wehler, "Ein deutsches Säkulum?", *Berliner Zeitung*, August 8, 1996; Alf Lüdtke, "'Helden der Arbeit'—Mühen beim Arbeiten. Zur mißmutigen Loyalität von Industriearbeitern in der DDR," in *Sozialgeschichte der DDR*, ed. Hartmut Kaelble, Jürgen Kocka, and Hartmut Zwahr (Stuttgart: Klett-Cotta, 1994), 188.

⁹ Anna Funder, *Stasiland: Stories from Behind the Berlin Wall* (New York: Harper Perennial, 2011); *Das Leben Der Anderen* (dir. Florian Henckel von Donnersmarck, Germany, 2006).

¹⁰ Andrew Demshuk, *Bowling for Communism: Urban Ingenuity at the End of East Germany* (Ithaca: Cornell University Press, 2020), 6.

either the idiosyncrasies of everyday life in the GDR or the appeal of the dictatorship at the time and in nostalgic memory today.¹¹ Mary Fulbrook's now-classic *The People's State* memorably begins with the question of *Ostalgie*—nostalgia for the East—by asking why, when “faced with accounts of repression, complicity and collusion, former citizens of the GDR claimed that their own memories and experiences told them otherwise.”¹² These works, taken together, convincingly pressed for what Fulbrook terms, “a ‘normality’ about the history of the GDR that needs to be recaptured.”¹³

In so doing, this cohort of scholars not only demolished the totalitarian hypothesis—among historians, at any rate—but also cleared a space for novel approaches, for scholarship that would not take Cold War presuppositions about the beneficence of liberal, capitalist democracy or the evil of state socialism as their points of departure. While many of the nine books under review here offer a brief overview of such theoretical interpretations, these debates are not their focus. Likewise, they are far less concerned with the Stasi and other repressive arms of the state than were earlier studies.

Instead, these monographs, which are the work of not only historians, but also scholars working in memory studies, anthropology, and urban studies, fan out in a multitude of thematic and methodological directions. Building on the foundations of earlier revisionist historiography, they consider everything from East German architecture in Vietnam to the fates of socialist monuments in the reunified republic. Though eclectic at first glance, these nine books help to define three new subfields within the historiography on East Germany. Those by Paul Stangl, Eli Rubin, and Andrew Demshuk focus on East Germany's urban history, highlighting the significance of the built environment and the contingency of its evolution. Those by Christina Schwenkel, Thomas Fleischman, and Ned Richardson-Little unearth transnational histories of the GDR, revealing complex international networks and relationships in which the country was entangled. Finally, those by Anna Saunders, Hope Harrison, and Amieke Bouma examine the GDR's afterlives since the *Wende*, interrogating its fraught place in Germany's famed memory culture.

While these works ask different questions of the East German past, they all also orbit around a new theoretical center. Deprived of the zeal with which scholars debated the GDR's alleged totalitarianism, the historiography on East Germany might well have lost its internal impetus. Yet this has not come to pass, for these works identify a new present-day concern, on which the socialist past can offer a fresh perspective. That is to say, each of them, to varying degrees and in different ways, is preoccupied with the crisis of liberal, capitalist democracy, through which we are currently living.

Urban Histories of the GDR

At the end of World War II, Germany's cities lay in ruin. Bombs had reduced some fifty percent of urban buildings to rubble. In Berlin, all but 380,000 of the city's 1.5 million apartments were damaged.¹⁴ Unsurprisingly, the battle to reclaim the urban environment began almost as soon as the war ended. Soviet occupiers soon replaced Nazi street signs with new, cardboard ones, while so-called rubble women cleared away debris. The destruction bequeathed East Germany's socialist rulers both an opportunity to reimagine the

¹¹ Andrew I. Port, *Conflict and Stability in the German Democratic Republic* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2007), 115; Paul Betts, *Within Walls: Private Life in the German Democratic Republic* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2010), 173–77; Josie McLellan, *Love in the Time of Communism: Intimacy and Sexuality in the GDR* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2011). On gender politics in East Germany, see too Donna Harsch, *Revenge of the Domestic: Women, the Family, and Communism in the German Democratic Republic* (Princeton: Princeton University Press, 2008).

¹² Mary Fulbrook, *The People's State: East German Society from Hitler to Honecker* (New Haven: Yale University Press, 2008), 1.

¹³ Fulbrook, *The People's State*, 10.

¹⁴ Eli Rubin, *Amnesiopolis: Modernity, Space, and Memory in East Germany* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2016), 20.

country's urban geography and an intractable housing problem that would plague the country for decades.

In the first years after the war, as socialist leaders grappled with this housing shortage, urban planning was not dominated by either socialist principles or Soviet dogma, Paul Stangl argues. His study of the rebuilding of Berlin in the late 1940s and early 1950s highlights genuine debates between planners who subscribed to modernist design and those steeped in socialist realism. Tasked by the country's leaders with solving the housing shortage, modernist planners initially focused on the concept of "residential cells" that would each house about four thousand people.¹⁵ But these planners soon found themselves in conflict with Soviet architects, who favored the more ornate aesthetic of Stalin-era socialist realism. Ultimately, Walter Ulbricht weighed in on the side of socialist realism, accusing modernist planners of "wanting to 'trivialize the capital of Germany' with low-rise buildings suitable for the outskirts of cities" (199), and throwing his clout behind those who advocated mammoth new prestige projects befitting a great city.

The best-known of these projects was Stalinallee (today Karl-Marx-Allee), which ran from Alexanderplatz to Frankfurter Tor. Architects planned monumental new buildings along the boulevard. It was, above all else, a propaganda piece, meant to lure West Berliners with the (false) promise of plentiful and luxurious housing. Yet the Stalinallee project soon became a propaganda nightmare. Laborers began arguing about quotas on June 12, 1953, Stangl recounts, and by June 15 some had gone on strike, eventually sparking the June 17 revolt that rocked the young socialist state. Eventually Ulbricht would backtrack, instructing planners to focus on standardized, mass housing. Thus Stangl contends that ideological battles over housing and architecture in the early years of the GDR were just that—battles. They were not preordained to turn out the way they did, just as it was not inevitable that East Germany would suffer from chronic housing shortages all the way up to 1989. Though he focuses more on elite views than everyday experiences, Stangl opens up space to think not just about the normality of East German governance—that is, the degree to which there existed social and political norms under which competing individuals, ideologies, and organizations exercised degrees of agency—but also the contingencies inherent to its evolution.¹⁶

Ulbricht's government never did get a handle on the housing crisis, and by the 1960s, it had come to a head. In spite of more standardized construction in the 1950s, East Germans struggled to find housing. Young couples often had to cohabit with their parents. Those lucky enough to live in their own unit frequently shared a toilet or had no hot water. When Erich Honecker came to power in 1971 promising the "unity of economic and social policy," he made housing a central focus of his rule. In 1973, his government inaugurated a new Housing Program (*Wohnungsbauprogramm*) with the goal of providing every East German a new apartment by 1990. Using prefabricated construction—so-called *Plattenbau*—the debt-financed program erected massive new settlements on the outskirts of major cities, building two million new apartments and refurbishing another one million over the course of sixteen years. By November 1989, forty-five percent of East Germans lived in prefabricated housing and over a quarter lived in settlements of one thousand apartments or more.

¹⁵ Paul Stangl, *Risen from the Ruins: The Cultural Politics of Rebuilding East Berlin* (Palo Alto: Stanford University Press, 2018), 192.

¹⁶ As noted above, "normality" and "normalization," which are most closely associated with Mary Fulbrook's work, have become signal concepts through which historians view East German society. Some scholars, such as Paul Betts, refer to how ordinary East Germans experienced a certain "normalization" of their daily lives under state socialism. Fulbrook defines normalization as a useful descriptor "to explore questions concerning the relative stabilisation of domestic political structures and processes [and] the degrees of routinisation and predictability of everyday practices." However used, the term contains an implicit rebuke of the totalitarian model, implying both restraint on state power and individual agency within the confines of certain norms. Betts, *Within Walls*, 38; Mary Fulbrook, "The Concept of 'Normalisation' and the GDR in Comparative Perspective," in *Power and Society in the GDR, 1961-1979: The 'Normalisation of Rule'?*, ed. Mary Fulbrook (New York: Berghahn Books, 2009), 13.

Eli Rubin unearths the “bottommost” layer of everyday life in Marzahn, the largest of these “concrete utopia[s]” (4, 6). In so doing, he argues that East Germans traded material comfort for a loss of connection to the past by relocating to such neighborhoods. These new settlements were nothing like the tenements most moved from. Everything from the climate to olfactory sensations molded residents into new socialist citizens. Ultimately, Rubin sees Marzahn and similar settlements not only as a means to house East Germans, but also as “a physical manifestation” of “socialism as an iteration of a kind of modernity; an all-encompassing Enlightenment project” (114). Like Stangl, Rubin thus takes the GDR seriously as a normal state that endeavored to construct a new vision of modernity.

Moreover, Rubin does not consider the regime’s struggle to resolve the housing crisis as a problem of socialism, writing “it is a highly questionable matter whether the American model is itself sustainable” (158). In fact, the protests of autumn 1989 burst forth from the decaying urban centers of East Germany’s cities, revealing, Rubin suggests, that had the regime succeeded in moving a larger proportion of the population into comfortable Plattenbaus, it might have weathered the storm. The SED simply “ran out of time” to realize the lofty goals of its housing program (155).

That crumbling urban core, conversely, is the subject of Andrew Demshuk’s page-turning microhistory, which forms a kind of companion piece to Rubin’s study. If Marzahn serves as a vivid illustration of the “utopia and dystopia” of real existing socialism (Rubin, 129), Demshuk offers an account of both the challenges and the opportunities of urban decay. Unearthing local planning initiatives in Leipzig, Demshuk’s object of study is the *Bowlingtreff*, a luxurious bowling establishment that the city built in the 1980s, largely without the approval or help of the central government. An example of what Demshuk terms “urban ingenuity” (4) the *Bowlingtreff* depended on genuine local enthusiasm and even a sort of grassroots democracy that challenged state power in the waning years of the GDR.

At the same time, the story of the bowling alley is not that, Demshuk sassily writes, of “a halcyon ‘people’s state’” (4). Leipzigers did not believe they had achieved the promise of socialism in building it (or other so-called *Schwartzbauten*). Rather, they thought the establishment, which was incidentally far better appointed than most capitalist bowling alleys, to be “a taste of the Imaginary West they hungered for each day” (138). So alluring was this “Imaginary West” that several of the alley’s employees—who had been vetted for loyalty—fled the country. These flights, which Demshuk discovered in local Stasi files, reveal that the *Bowlingtreff* had not sated Leipzigers’ dissatisfaction with socialism. Such urban unhappiness, Demshuk (like Rubin) argues, helped spark the unrest of 1989. When the government slated the historic town of Görlitz for demolition in 1989, for instance, it led to a panic around the country. Likewise, though, Demshuk does not understand these problems to be uniquely socialist in nature. Concluding in post-Wende Leipzig, Demshuk notes how capitalism “stole some of Leipzig residents’ fire about saving their built environment” (175). Today, the *Bowlingtreff* stands empty, a shell of its former self.

These three works reveal the extent to which struggles over housing and urban space in the GDR were both highly contingent and not so terribly different from similar struggles playing out in other parts of the world, including the capitalist West. Indeed, the East German housing crisis rhymes all too well with the one roiling capitalist cities today. Stangl, Rubin, and Demshuk use the East German past to hold up an mirror to our own society, revealing the possibilities of individual initiative and utopian planning alike, while also serving as a cautionary tale about the failures of both state socialism and liberal capitalism to solve this most intractable of problems.

Transnational East Germany

Although the SED never resolved East Germany’s housing problem—among other perpetual crises that defined its rule—the country nonetheless turned confidently to the world stage, seeking to valorize its experiment in real existing socialism. Transnational histories of the

GDR have begun to appear in new historiography that takes East Germany seriously as an independent state, rather than merely a Soviet colony or a foil to West Germany. When it came to relationships with other socialist countries, the GDR pursued bold initiatives. In some cases, it even exported its building program, as Christina Schwenkel recounts in her study of Quang Trung, an East German housing development in the Vietnamese city of Vinh. Schwenkel conducted extensive oral histories and ethnographic work in both countries. Like Rubin, she is interested in how planned space produces affective communities, how “hope in a brighter future of peace and prosperity were closely tied to transformative materiality.”¹⁷ Hers is an expansive work that makes interventions in Vietnamese and East German historiographies as well as urban studies, ultimately arguing that the Quang Trung development reveals the emergence of a specifically socialist modernity during the Cold War.

During the Vietnam War, the United States Air Force bombed Vinh relentlessly, subjecting it to more than four thousand sorties over eight years. One woman whom Schwenkel interviewed remembered, “I saw nothing but rubble” (75). East Germans connected the city’s fate to their own in World War II, especially the firebombing of Dresden. Moreover, aiding Vietnam fit well within East German efforts to cultivate solidarity for anti-colonial struggles around the world.¹⁸ As discussed below, Ned Richardson-Little argues East German thinkers developed a vision of human rights centered on decolonization. This vision manifested itself in places like Vinh, where East German planners and engineers actually helped build a massive complex of high-rise apartments.

In spite of their utopian design, the plans were marred by neocolonial misunderstandings and neglect from the start. The GDR sent used and obsolete equipment, which led to frequent breakdowns, delays in construction, and, ultimately, the “secondhand modernity” that East Germany had gifted Vinh” (320). East Germans also struggled to understand Vietnamese norms, seeking to impose their own assumptions about work, family life, and leisure through planning. For example, they wanted to plant palm trees on the central Victory Square, which, their Vietnamese counterparts pointed out, would offer scant shade from the punishing midday sun. Nonetheless, Vinh residents still see the buildings as a success. According to Schwenkel, “In Vinh, being German was associated with moral goodness and technological prowess” (13). For all their superficial decay, “the most durable and disaster-resistant housing in Vinh was East German-made” (293). Schwenkel thus casts East German urbanism in a new, transnational light, revealing the complexities of the regime’s foreign initiatives, while also recapturing something utopian in the East German past that might challenge neoliberalism’s hegemony in the present.

A converse but complimentary argument emerges from Thomas Fleischman’s history of East Germany’s romance with the industrial pig. Although Fleischman’s beautifully written book follows the animal that he lovingly calls “the very ideal of charismatic megafauna,”¹⁹ it is really a history of how global markets changed in the 1970s and 1980s and, in turn, changed everything from eating habits to the environment. Starting in the 1960s, East German economic planners became enthralled with American-style agribusiness and planned to replicate it. In 1969, the pig-breeding and -fattening combine Eberswalde opened, a mammoth industrial center stocked with pigs bred to withstand the travails of industrial agriculture.

Initially, the plan seemed like a success. With assistance from the Western creditors who also helped build Marzahn, East Germany doubled its pork output by 1981. But pigs require

¹⁷ Christina Schwenkel, *Building Socialism: The Afterlife of East German Architecture in Urban Vietnam* (Durham, NC: Duke University Press, 2020), 2.

¹⁸ For more on East German solidarity efforts, see Quinn Slobodian, ed., *Comrades of Color: East Germany in the Cold War World* (New York: Berghahn Books, 2015).

¹⁹ Thomas Fleischman, *Communist Pigs: An Animal History of East Germany’s Rise and Fall* (Seattle: University of Washington Press, 2020), 9.

vast quantities of fodder, which economic planners tried to provide by saturating arable land with nitrate fertilizers. These chemicals, however, found their way into the pigs themselves and thus the human food chain. Moreover, weaned on a diet largely devoid of roughage, the pigs produced liquid and semi-liquid bodily waste, toxic sludge that planners had little idea how to deal with. Farmers soon began depositing the waste wherever they thought no one would notice. The results were catastrophic: poisoned lakes that were “opaque, slimy, and devoid of fish” (111), toxic nitrate levels in the drinking water consumed by nearly 3 million East Germans, and increased rates of cancer and blue baby syndrome.

But these were not the wages of socialism, Fleischman argues, rather those of capitalism. The foreign debt that East Germany accumulated and the environmental catastrophe in the GDR were not separate problems but rather “two sides of the same coin” (115). Thus, Fleischmann suggests that much of what was “wrong” with East Germany had to do with the international capitalist systems in which it was imbricated. “So what was it that tied the East German experience to this global history of agricultural pollution?” Fleischman’s answer: “It was capitalism” (115). In offering such a counterintuitive explanation of East Germany’s environmental catastrophe, Fleischman does not shift responsibility away from its government, which, after all, implicated itself and its economy in systems of global capital. Rather, by according blame to capitalism, Fleischman highlights the interconnectedness of the Cold War world, while also disabusing readers of the notion that socialism was to blame for all of the Eastern Bloc’s ills.

Like most of the other works under consideration here, Fleischman remains profoundly skeptical of post-1990 developments, contending that the reunification was greenwashed. “Under the cover of environmental remediation,” he writes, “wealthy West Germans and politically privileged East Germans seized the most valuable assets for themselves and left the pollution, destroyed forests, and work of remaking Germany’s industrial economy to everybody else” (202). As we grapple with the catastrophe of climate change, the world thus “becomes more like East Germany every day” (207).

Ned Richardson-Little traces a similarly counterintuitive narrative in his history of human rights and the GDR. Far from an authoritarian system that rejected the very notion of human rights, he contends, the GDR actually saw itself as a global leader in it. Drawing on both recent scholarship that questions contemporary assumptions about human rights and revisionist historiography that has emphasized the sophistication of SED rule, Richardson-Little reveals how the party slowly adopted and applied a peculiar vision of human rights.²⁰

Richardson-Little’s book begins with the SED’s electoral catastrophe of 1946, the only (partially) free elections the party ever contested. The SPD, which won an astonishing 48.7% of the vote in Berlin, where the election was freer than in the rest of the Soviet Zone, hammered the SED for human rights abuses. That defeat prompted thinkers in the East to begin elucidating a socialist theory of human rights. When the Federal Republic adopted the Hallstein Doctrine in 1955, which mandated West Germany would only establish diplomatic relations with countries that did not recognize the GDR, the SED created the Committee for the Protection of Human Rights in response.²¹ It was the first such organization in the Soviet Bloc. Initially advocating for the release of imprisoned communists in the Federal Republic, the committee eventually turned to anti-colonial solidarity as its banner issue – a domestic partner to foreign projects like the Quang Trung development in Vinh.

²⁰ On the historiography of human rights, see, *inter alia*, Samuel Moyn, *The Last Utopia: Human Rights in History* (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 2012); Moyn, *Not Enough: Human Rights in an Unequal World* (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 2018); Jessica Whyte, *The Morals of the Market: Human Rights and the Rise of Neoliberalism* (London: Verso Books, 2019).

²¹ Ned Richardson-Little, *The Human Rights Dictatorship: Socialism, Global Solidarity and Revolution in East Germany* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2020), 54. For more on the Hallstein Doctrine, see William Glenn Gray, *Germany’s Cold War: The Global Campaign to Isolate East Germany, 1949–1969* (Chapel Hill: The University of North Carolina Press, 2003).

As a result of its increasingly assertive advocacy of human rights, the GDR signed on to numerous international conventions and treaties, not least the famed Helsinki Accords of 1975. While many historians view the Accords as a turning point, when Western nations tricked socialist governments into accepting human rights, Richardson-Little argues instead that “SED and party elites had already internalized the concept of human rights as an essential part of the socialist project” (98). By the 1980s, though, he acknowledges that human rights had become “a useful discourse of dissent” (178). “The SED’s long-standing embrace of human rights discourse was fundamental to the peaceful revolution,” Richardson-Little contends, “because it created the shared language between those in power and those without” (254). Ultimately, then, the “human rights dictatorship” abolished itself “to realize its own ideals” (254). Yet those ideals were not, perhaps, realized in the *Wende*. Richardson-Little too is critical of reunification, dwelling on its consequences for East German women who, in addition to losing access to on-demand abortion in the first trimester, also lost “social and economic rights, such as state-provided childcare, that had previously facilitated their independence through participation in the workforce” (261).

Of course, the portrait Richardson-Little paints of the GDR is of an opportunistic regime using the language of human rights for its own ends. But this is precisely the point: what regime does not use human rights in this way? The wealth of scholarship on human rights over the last decade reveals just how intertwined ideology and opportunism are within Western human rights practices. East Germany, Richardson-Little shows, was less different than we might imagine. In this way—much like Fleischman’s work—Richardson-Little holds up a mirror to the practices of liberal democracy, asking us if we are really so very different. The point, of course, is not to efface the very real differences between East Germany and Western countries, but rather to underline how, on a host of issues and problems, those differences were less categorical and more a matter of degrees.

The Many Afterlives of the GDR

If there is something that connects virtually all of the works considered above, it is the skepticism with which they view reunification. Although over thirty years have passed since East Germany legally ceased to exist on October 3, 1990, East Germany has lingered socially and culturally in numerous ways, from monuments that have been left standing, to the *Ostalgie* that permeates contemporary culture, to the AfD’s stunning electoral results. It is therefore unsurprising that scholars have turned to how the GDR is remembered and memorialized in reunified Germany.

Of the three monographs concerned with these matters, Hope Harrison’s is both the deepest and the narrowest, focused on how parts of the Berlin Wall have been destroyed, memorialized, and preserved since November 9, 1989. Relying on dozens of oral histories that she collected over the course of almost twenty years, Harrison paints a nuanced portrait of different stakeholders and how their idiosyncratic views shaped efforts to remember the Wall and especially its victims. Because of this emphasis on victims of the border regime, the book at times appears to eschew much of the contemporary historiography, sometimes painting East Germany in simplistic terms. Describing a 1989 performance of Beethoven’s opera *Fidelio*, for instance, Harrison writes, “Just as the prisoners [in the opera] wanted freedom and not to be watched all the time, East Germans in Dresden and elsewhere wanted the same.”²²

Across a series of in-depth case studies, from the Bernauerstraße Berlin Wall Memorial to the activities of Alexandra Hildebrandt, the director of the Checkpoint Charlie Museum, Harrison focuses on two overarching conflicts in East German memory culture. On the one hand was the fraught question of whether Germany could pay homage to those who had died at the Wall without cheapening the suffering of the Holocaust’s victims. There was immense outcry, for instance, when Hildebrandt said a makeshift memorial she had

²² Hope M. Harrison, *After the Berlin Wall: Memory and the Making of the New Germany, 1989 to the Present* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2019), 47.

erected to honor those killed at the GDR border was “a counterpart to the Holocaust memorial” (180).

On the other hand, people agitating for memorials were divided between those who wanted lifelike recreations of the Berlin Wall and those who wanted more abstract sites of remembrance. The latter group accused the former of advocating a “Disneyland” approach to traumatic memory (213). The former rebutted that their critics wanted to whitewash the SED regime by forcing moral ambiguity on what, in their minds, was “a simple, basic narrative: the Wall and the SED regime behind it were evil” (214). Although the Wall is now a firm fixture in Berlin’s tourism industry—the Bernauerstraße Berlin Wall Memorial welcomed one million visitors in 2018—these divisions remain. Scholarly consensus may exist that the GDR was a complex state that relied on nuanced forms of consent and coercion to maintain its rule, but this consensus is not always reflected in popular discourse.

Such conflicts are also the subject of Anna Saunders’ broad and engaging work that examines how East Germany has been (de)memorialized in the years since 1989. Each chapter focuses on a different site of memory, from former socialist statues to Soviet Zone special camps. In each instance, Saunders emphasizes striking disagreements about memorialization plans and the political stakes of these disputes. Looking at monuments constructed by the SED regime, for instance, she highlights how different localities took very different approaches to socialist statues. While a large statue of Lenin in Berlin came down in the early 1990s, other statues, including that of Weimar-era communist leader Ernst Thälmann and the massive Karl Marx head in Chemnitz both remained. In fact, the Marx statue is now one of the city’s most popular tourist attractions—a striking illustration of how *Ostalgie* has become a profitable enterprise. Ironically, when local politicians, often from the Christian Democratic Union (CDU), tried to tear these monuments down in the early 1990s, voters accused them of behaving just like the SED.

Even more consequentially, Saunders dwells on how East German history has offered the newly reunified Berlin Republic a redemptive historical narrative, one that stretches from the 1953 uprisings to the 1989 revolution and ultimately reunification in 1990. As Harrison also notes, such an arc contrasts sharply with the memory culture that has grown up around the Holocaust. Moreover, Saunders highlights the tensions within this narrative between the so-called “winners” and “losers” of reunification.²³ She describes, for instance, how Western politicians dominated the twentieth-anniversary commemoration of the Wall falling on November 9, 2009. Eastern activists have been pushed out of the limelight of such events, which have failed to resonate with “experiences of high unemployment and a shrinking population in the eastern *Länder*.” That disconnect, Saunders argues, has “led to disillusionment among many, not only among former activists, and contributed to election successes of the PDS/Die Linke in the East”—and, we might add, also the AfD (254). Saunders’ approach to East German memorialization allows her to home in on how phenomena such as *Ostalgie* do not always represent identification with the GDR *per se*, but rather “a sense of oppositional solidarity in the present” (13), of opposition to the ways that the *Wende* brought about the immiseration of former East German lands.

Ostalgie also takes center stage in Amieke Bouma’s book, which sheds light on the East German Board of Associations (OKV). This umbrella organization arose in the years after the *Wende* to advocate for the interests of East Germans, in particular former state employees, and to maintain social connections among them. In order to write about this organization, which claimed some 25,000 members in the mid-1990s and has declined since, Bouma conducted oral interviews with thirty-two of its members. Although Bouma ultimately finds the OKV to be “inconsequential,”²⁴ she contends that it is representative of the way that

²³ Anna Saunders, *Memorializing the GDR: Monuments and Memory after 1989* (New York: Berghahn Books, 2018), 173, 297.

²⁴ Amieke Bouma, *German Post-Socialist Memory Culture: Epistemic Nostalgia* (Amsterdam: Amsterdam University Press, 2019), 281.

politicized nostalgia can be maintained by an “epistemic community” through an “impressive feedback loop” of purpose, memory, and social networks (194).

As in Saunders and Harrison’s works, Bouma identifies different ways of viewing the East German past prevalent today, including the totalitarianism hypothesis and the accommodation thesis (namely, that East Germans accommodated themselves to the regime). She also identifies a narrative of progress, or “Fortschrittsgedächtnis,” that is common among OKV members. They hold that the GDR was a legitimate state which endeavored to enact radical, progressive reforms. Even as members occasionally acknowledged problems with the GDR, these individuals were reluctant to criticize it as such, a trend Bouma terms a “compartmentalization of memory” (63). She thus identifies the peculiar variant of *Ostalgie* prevalent among OKV members as “nostalgia not so much for the way the GDR was, but for the way in which the GDR understood itself to be” (84). Because this group remains so insular, cut off from larger groups and parties (Die Linke actively distances itself from the OKV), its interpretation of the GDR has found little resonance among the broader public and does little to explain the broader appeal of *Ostalgie*, especially among those born after the *Wende*.

Although the OKV as an organization can thus explain relatively little about Germany today, Bouma’s study suggests that historians and memory scholars might think of the GDR not only as a state that ceased to exist on October 3, 1990, but also as an affective community that has and will continue to encompass large swaths of Germans. Indeed, most studies under consideration here express a deep skepticism about the process of stitching the two countries back together, highlighting why East Germans might retain a certain fondness for their former country. These authors focus on what was lost when East Germany ceased to exist as well as the corruption, ineptitude, and violence that attended reunification. The success of the AfD in those parts of Germany that lost the most in 1990 should thus not surprise us, as disillusioned East Germans cast protest votes or turn to what may seem as genuine alternatives to decades of failed reunification.

Conclusion

Almost ten years ago, Andrew Port asked whether “the GDR—to put it crudely—[was] a ‘worse’ place than the United States,” wondering “how an African American youth from Detroit, where infant mortality, crime, and poverty rates rival those of many developing countries, might answer this question.” Responding for this imagined individual, Port asserted, “He or she would most likely not exchange ‘freedom’ and the possibility of ‘making it big one day’ for more modest material ‘security’.”²⁵ Even if Port’s ventriloquized answer were reasonable in 2013, it is by no means certain that it would be so today. Everything from the climate strikes to the growth of right-wing populism illustrate that citizens are increasingly disillusioned with the hegemony of neoliberal democracy that seemed so certain at the “end of history.” While few progressives aim to establish a system of state socialism, the material safety and relative equity of East German society appear far more appealing in the wake of the 2008 financial crisis, four years of the Trump presidency, and the inability of the United States government to deliver even the most basic care to its citizens. That is to say, the twin crises of capitalism and of liberal democracy have demolished that Cold War-era confidence in Western goodness and the evil of the Soviet Bloc. As we recognize these crises and the grotesque failures that caused them, it becomes harder and harder to see East Germany as especially bad. Even the Stasi—though not the focus of any of these works—seems less of an outlier in the modern history of state security when compared to Western intelligence practices from J. Edgar Hoover’s FBI to the Five Eyes surveillance program. And perhaps, as some of these new histories suggest, there might even be something worth salvaging from the environmental, economic, and urban wreckage of the GDR.

²⁵ Port, “Introduction,” 23–24.

In rejecting Manichaean Cold War divisions, the scholarship considered here has also turned away from the more traditional foci of historiography on East Germany. Whereas earlier works debated the role of the Stasi in East Germany's state and society or interrogated the particulars of private life in the GDR, more recent works bring to light new archives of urban studies, legal history, memory culture, and environmental history that paint a more multifaceted picture of both the state and public life under state socialism. That is to say, the portrait of East Germany that emerges through these texts is the product not only of shifting political preoccupations, but also of scholars' attentiveness to new research methods and novel sources.

Moreover, the works considered here suggest that East German history will remain a vibrant and methodologically sophisticated field. Just as the first generation of revisionist historians demolished the totalitarian hypothesis and paved the way for histories that could take the GDR's normality as their point of departure, these works have given us far richer portraits of East German society and its state apparatus. There is likely to be further work in all of these subfields, especially studies that interrogate the GDR's lingering presence in reunified Germany. There are also already signs of other new directions in the field, such as studies of social outsiders in the GDR, from Vietnamese workers to Black Germans to queer people. As East Germany recedes from living memory, it will come to seem less bizarre—less of an accident of history—while also offering ever more ways of interrogating the present. It may also offer up utopian visions, flashes of inspiration that might serve not only as a warning but also as an impetus to a better future. “In a time of capitalist restructuring,” Schwenkel writes, “where land's value now comes before people's needs, it may be worth preserving the traces of this past dreamworld of future possibilities” (321).